



Python Programming Fundamentals

Parameters and Return Values

Programming Fundamentals Team

SETU

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Outline

- 1. Positional Parameters**
- 2. Keyword Arguments**
- 3. Default Parameter Values**
- 4. The return Statement**
- 5. Multiple Return Values**
- 6. Conditional Returns**
- 7. Designing Good Functions**



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1. Positional Parameters

Parameters are variables that receive values when the function is called. **Arguments** are the values passed by the caller.

```
def greet(name, time_of_day):      # name, time_of_day are parameters
    print(f"Good {time_of_day}, {name}!")
```

```
greet("Alice", "morning")          # positional – order matters
greet("Bob", "evening")
```



1. Positional Parameters

Positional arguments are matched to parameters **in order** — the first argument goes to the first parameter, the second to the second, and so on.

```
def power(base, exponent):  
    return base ** exponent
```

```
print(power(2, 8))      # 2^8 = 256  
print(power(8, 2))      # 8^2 = 64 (different order, different result!)
```



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2. Keyword Arguments

Keyword arguments are passed by **name**, so order doesn't matter.

```
def create_user(username, email, age):  
    print(f"User: {username}, Email: {email}, Age: {age}")  
  
# Keyword arguments – any order  
create_user(email="alice@example.com", age=25, username="alice99")
```



2. Keyword Arguments

Keyword arguments are passed by **name**, so order doesn't matter.

```
def create_user(username, email, age):  
    print(f"User: {username}, Email: {email}, Age: {age}")
```

Keyword arguments – any order

```
create_user(email="alice@example.com", age=25, username="alice99")
```

You can **mix** positional and keyword arguments – positional must come first:

```
create_user("alice99", age=25, email="alice@example.com") # OK  
# create_user(username="alice99", "alice@example.com", 25) # SyntaxError
```



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3. Default Parameter Values

Give a parameter a **default value** so it becomes optional at the call site.

```
def greet(name, greeting="Hello"):
    print(f"{greeting}, {name}!")
```

```
greet("Alice")           # Hello, Alice!
greet("Bob", "Hi")       # Hi, Bob!
greet("Carol", greeting="Good morning") # Good morning, Carol!
```



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4. The return Statement

return sends a value back to the caller and **immediately exits** the function.

```
def square(n):  
    return n * n
```

```
result = square(7)          # result = 49  
print(square(5) + 1)        # 26  
print(square(square(3)))    # 81
```



4. The return Statement

A function can have **multiple return statements** — the first one reached exits the function:

```
def absolute_value(n):  
    if n < 0:  
        return -n          # exits here for negatives  
    return n               # exits here for non-negatives  
  
print(absolute_value(-5))  # 5  
print(absolute_value(7))  # 7
```



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5. Multiple Return Values

Python functions can return **multiple values** as a tuple.

```
def min_max(numbers):  
    """Return the minimum and maximum of a list."""  
    return min(numbers), max(numbers)
```

```
lo, hi = min_max([3, 1, 7, 4, 2, 8, 5])  
print(f"Min: {lo}, Max: {hi}")    # Min: 1, Max: 8
```



5. Multiple Return Values

Tuple unpacking on the left side:

```
def divide_with_remainder(a, b):  
    quotient = a // b  
    remainder = a % b  
    return quotient, remainder
```

```
q, r = divide_with_remainder(17, 5)  
print(f"17 ÷ 5 = {q} remainder {r}")    # 17 ÷ 5 = 3 remainder 2
```

Or get the full tuple:

```
result = divide_with_remainder(100, 7)  
print(result)    # (14, 2)
```



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6.1 Ternary Expression

A **ternary expression** returns one of two values on a single line:

```
return <value_if_true> if <condition> else <value_if_false>
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```

```
def is_even(n):  
    return "even" if n % 2 == 0 else "odd"
```

```
def absolute_value(n):  
    return n if n >= 0 else -n
```

```
print(is_even(4))          # even  
print(is_even(7))          # odd  
print(absolute_value(-5))  # 5
```



6.1 Ternary Expression

A **ternary expression** returns one of two values on a single line:

```
return <value_if_true> if <condition> else <value_if_false>
```

```
def is_even(n):  
    return "even" if n % 2 == 0 else "odd"
```

```
def absolute_value(n):  
    return n if n >= 0 else -n
```

```
print(is_even(4))          # even  
print(is_even(7))          # odd  
print(absolute_value(-5))  # 5
```

Use the ternary when there are exactly **two** outcomes and both fit clearly on one line. For three or more branches, use chained returns instead (see next slide).



6.2 Chained Early Returns

When a function has **multiple branches**, return from each one immediately — no `elif` needed. The first return reached exits the function:

```
def calculate_grade(score):  
    """Return a letter grade for a numeric score."""  
    if score >= 90: return "A"  
    if score >= 80: return "B"  
    if score >= 70: return "C"  
    if score >= 60: return "D"  
    return "F"           # fallback – only reached if all above are False  
  
print(calculate_grade(95))    # A  
print(calculate_grade(73))    # C  
print(calculate_grade(42))    # F
```



6.2 Chained Early Returns

Why not `elif`? Once a return fires, the function is already finished — Python never reaches the next `if`. This means `elif` is unnecessary, and removing it makes the logic easier to scan top to bottom.



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The final bare return `"F"` is the **catch-all** — it only runs if every condition above was `False`.



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7. Designing Good Functions

Good functions:

- Do **one thing** well (single responsibility)
- Have a clear, descriptive name
- Have a docstring
- Accept inputs as parameters
- Return output via return (don't print inside unless displaying is the function's job)



7. Designing Good Functions

BAD – function does too many things and mixes I/O with logic

```
def process():  
    name = input("Name: ")  
    score = float(input("Score: "))  
    grade = "Pass" if score >= 60 else "Fail"  
    print(f"{name}: {grade}")
```

GOOD – separate concerns

```
def get_input(prompt):  
    return input(prompt)  
  
def calculate_grade(score):  
    return "Pass" if score >= 60 else "Fail"  
  
def display_result(name, grade):  
    print(f"{name}: {grade}")
```



7. Designing Good Functions

```
name = get_input("Name: ")
score = float(get_input("Score: "))
grade = calculate_grade(score)
display_result(name, grade)
```



Thanks for Watching - Any questions?

